



Great Barrier Reef

The world's largest coral reef lies in the Coral Sea off Australia's northeastern coast. More than 1,500 species of fish are found in its waters.

Bouncing "roos"

Australia is home to millions of kangaroos. Their powerful legs help them leap up to 30 ft (9 m) in a single hop and reach a top speed of 44 mph (71 km/h).



Eucalyptus forests

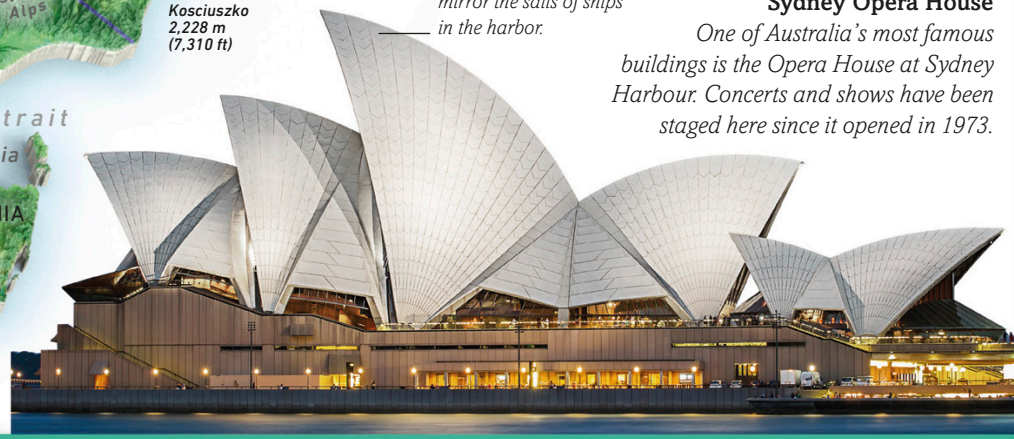
About three-quarters of Australia's forests are made up of eucalyptuses, tough trees able to survive the hot, dry Australian summers.



The design of the roofs mirror the sails of ships in the harbor.

Sydney Opera House

One of Australia's most famous buildings is the Opera House at Sydney Harbour. Concerts and shows have been staged here since it opened in 1973.



Venomous snakes

Three species of taipan, including this inland taipan, are native to Australia. They are highly venomous.



Geography: The central desert region is edged by grasslands, rain forests, mountains, and beaches.

History: The indigenous Australian Aborigines were the first people to arrive and settle in Australia more than 50,000 years ago.

Culture: Australians enjoy adventures in the great outdoors and the water and are a great sporting nation.

Natural wonders: The dramatic landscape ranges from the Great Barrier Reef to the Great Dividing Range.

Wildlife: Marsupials (animals that raise young in pouches), such as kangaroos and koalas, are unique to Australia.

Food and drink: Australian food is as multicultural as its people, with a mix of local, Asian, and Mediterranean dishes.